

An abstract painting of a face, rendered in a cubist style. The face is composed of various geometric shapes and textures. The most prominent feature is a pair of large, circular eyes with thick blue rims. The background is a mix of warm, earthy tones like yellow, orange, and brown, with some cooler blue and grey accents. The overall composition is dynamic and expressive.

blessed by the **bees**
a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**

20 June – 31 July 2026
SPRINGS ART GALLERY

blessed by the **bees**

Co-Curated by :
Chepape Makgato & Thabo Sekoaila

The exhibition foregrounds Professor Mda's interdisciplinary practice, which traverses literature, visual art, memory, history, and social critique.

BRIEF BIO & ARTIST STATEMENT

Zakes Mda is a South African writer, music composer, and painter. His practice as an artist integrates all those disciplines. For instance, his music compositions may be for his musical plays such as *The Bells of Amersfoort* or score his animations and installations.

His art celebrates the coalescence of the materials and traditions of the diverse regions of the world in which he has worked. These include Johannesburg, the rural Eastern Cape, Lesotho, and the Appalachian USA. His practice is largely intertextual; utilizing mixed media dominated by acrylic or oil on canvas, collaged with fabric, newsprint and an assembly of conceptual three-dimensional found objects. Each painting functions as a narrative of domestic, gender and workplace tensions. Some works pay homage to performance – particularly dance and music – in a manner these art forms function as a healing force in society.

He also engages in conventional modes of expression occasionally, focusing on the media of acrylics and oils on canvas, pre-Renaissance encaustic wax on canvas, and black-and-white and color linocuts on paper. The works are a fusion of styles drawing variously from Basotho traditional murals called *litema* and *lipatrone*, and European expressionist modes, particularly Braque-inspired Cubism (itself inspired by various African mask traditions). Quite often there is symbiosis between his painting and writing as some of his art is influenced by or loosely interprets scenes and characters of his novels.

His paintings have been exhibited in South Africa, Lesotho and the USA and are in collections in those countries and in Spain, Switzerland and Sweden. His most recent solo exhibitions were at the SA Consulate in New York City (2021), *The Viewing Room*, Pretoria (2022), *Keys Art Mile* in Rosebank Johannesburg (2023), and *William Humphrey Art Gallery* in Kimberley (2023/24). Recent group exhibitions include at the *Polokwane Art Gallery* with *Khehla Chepape Makgato* (2022), at the *BKHz Gallery* in Rosebank Johannesburg (2025), with several other artists, and at an invitation-only *Colours of Compassion* art exhibition and auction alongside William Kentridge at *The Venue*, Melrose Boulevard, for the *Smile Foundation*.

Mda holds an MFA (Theater) and an MA (Telecommunications) from Ohio University, and a PhD from the University of Cape Town.

He has been awarded honorary doctorates in literature by the University of Cape Town, the University of the Witwatersrand, and the University of the Free State, in technology by the Central University of Technology and the Durban University of Technology, and in art by Dartmouth College in the USA.

He has published 30 books, eleven of which are novels and the rest collections of plays, collections of essays, an autobiography, a biography, poetry and a monograph on the theory and practice of theater-for-development.

His writings have been translated into more than 25 languages, including Mandarin, Estonian, Catalan, Korean, Serbian, German, Swedish, Dutch, Turkish, Norwegian and Italian. They have won many awards in South Africa, the USA and Italy, including the Amstel Playwright of the Year Award, the Commonwealth Writers Prize for Africa, the M-Net Prize, Sanlam Prizes (twice), The Pringle Award, the Sunday Times Literary Prize (twice), the Zora Neale Hurston/Richard Wright Legacy Award, Premio Narrativa Sud del Mondo, the University of Johannesburg Literary Prize and the American Library Association Notable Book. He is a recipient of the Order of Ikhamanga in Silver, a national award of the South African government. He is Professor Emeritus at Ohio University where he taught Creative Writing, Rhetoric, and Literature for 15 years, and was a beekeeper on Dyarhom Mountain in the Eastern Cape (running a project he established in 2000 with rural women).

Curatorial Statement

Selecting works for this exhibition was both an honour and a demanding curatorial undertaking. The sheer volume and richness of the work produced by Zakes Mda, housed in his studio in Rosebank, offer an abundance that could easily overwhelm any attempt at restraint. Each piece carries its own narrative weight, making the act of selection an exercise in careful distillation rather than exclusion.

Blessed by the Bees, as a title, finds poetic and conceptual resonance within Mda's lifelong community work. For those familiar with his life and practice, the reference to bees is neither incidental nor decorative – it speaks directly to his longstanding commitment to beekeeping in the Eastern Cape, an activity that exists in parallel with his artistic and intellectual pursuits. Here, the bee becomes both a metaphor and method, symbolising labour, community, discipline, and the delicate balance between creation and vulnerability.

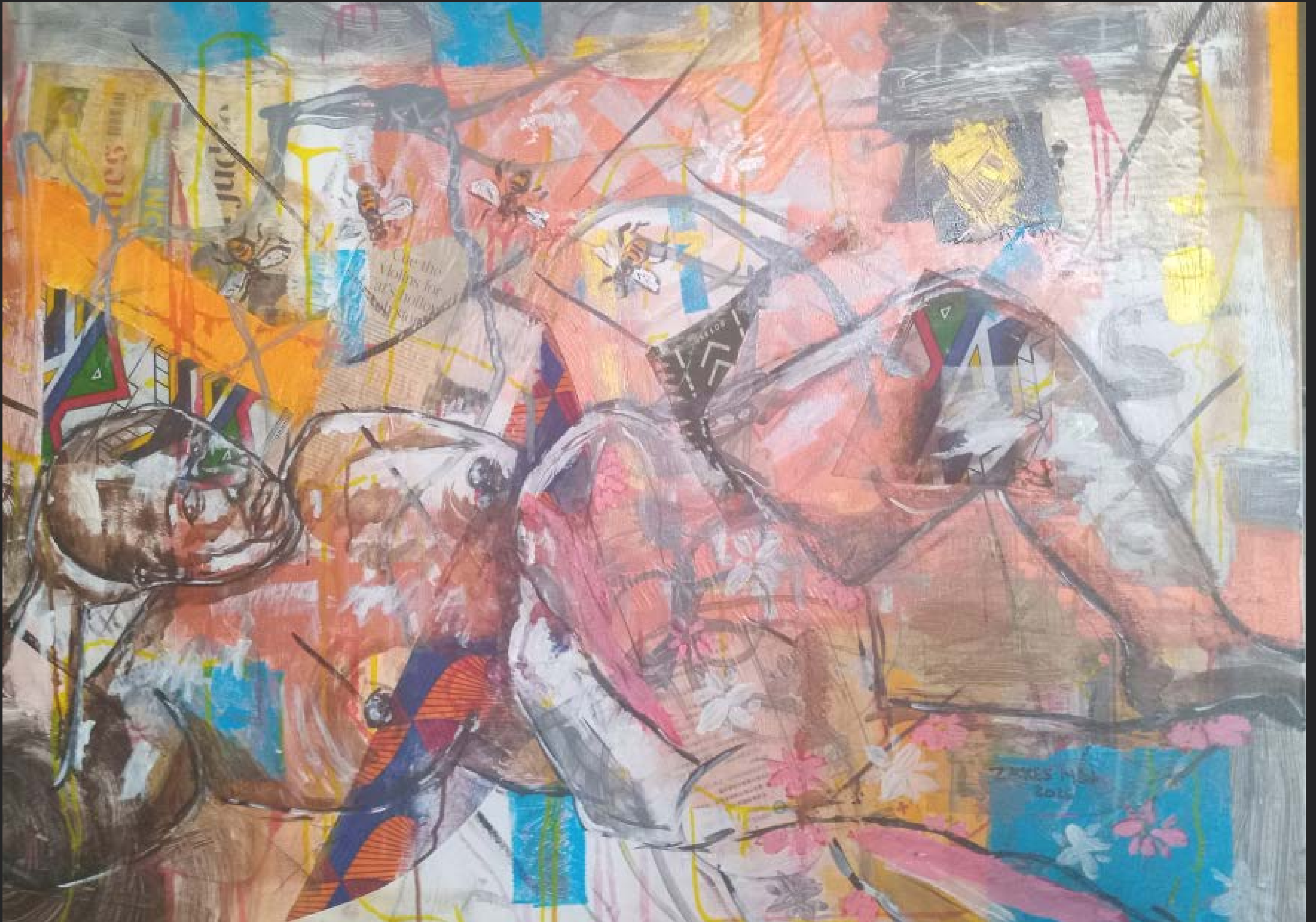
Several works in the exhibition, including the featured image on the exhibition poster, reveal recurring self-portraits situated across varied environments. These visual reflections render the exhibition deeply autobiographical, positioning Mda not only as a creator but also a subject. Through these shifting self-representations, the viewer encounters a layered identity, one that traverses geography, memory, and imagination.

The colourful palette that defines much of the work echoes Mda's literary sensibilities. Much like his storytelling, the compositions are vivid, textured, and immersive. Each frame operates as a narrative portal, inviting the viewer into a world where visual and literary languages converge. Subtle insertions of bees here, and hives there, function as both motif and signal, suggesting an impending sensory encounter, a “sting” that is as aesthetic as it is intellectual.

What is particularly striking about Mda's creative output is his refusal to be confined. He challenges the compartmentalisation often imposed by disciplinary boundaries. Instead, he embraces a holistic creative identity, one that fluidly navigates scholarship, theatre, literature, music, and visual art. As a scholar, playwright, novelist, and composer, Mda brings a rare interdisciplinary depth to his visual practice. His work ultimately dares the viewer to reconsider the limits of artistic categorisation, reminding us of that creativity, like the hive, thrives in multiplicity and interconnectedness.

The *Blessed by the Bees* art exhibition explores themes of familiarity and estrangement that have marked Zakes Mda's work over recent years, heavily featuring motifs of memory, imagination, and presence in a psyche's effort to locate itself in place and time.

blessed by the **bees**



Artist in Recline

2026

Mixed media on canvas
122 x 91cm

R100,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



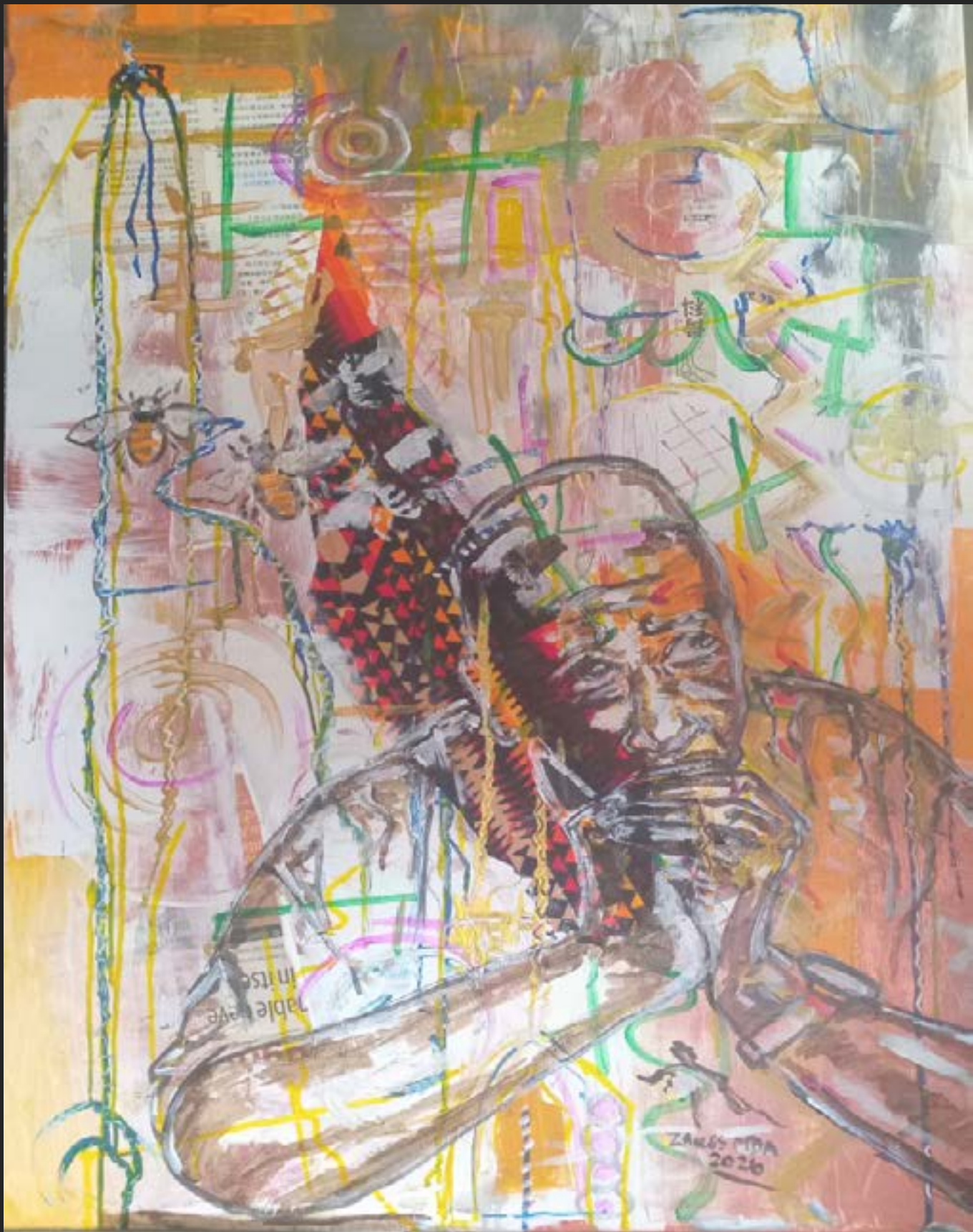
Community

2026

Mixed media on canvas
112 × 91cm

R100,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



Artist in Meditation

2026
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm

R100,000.00



Indlela Esihambayo

2026
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm

R100,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



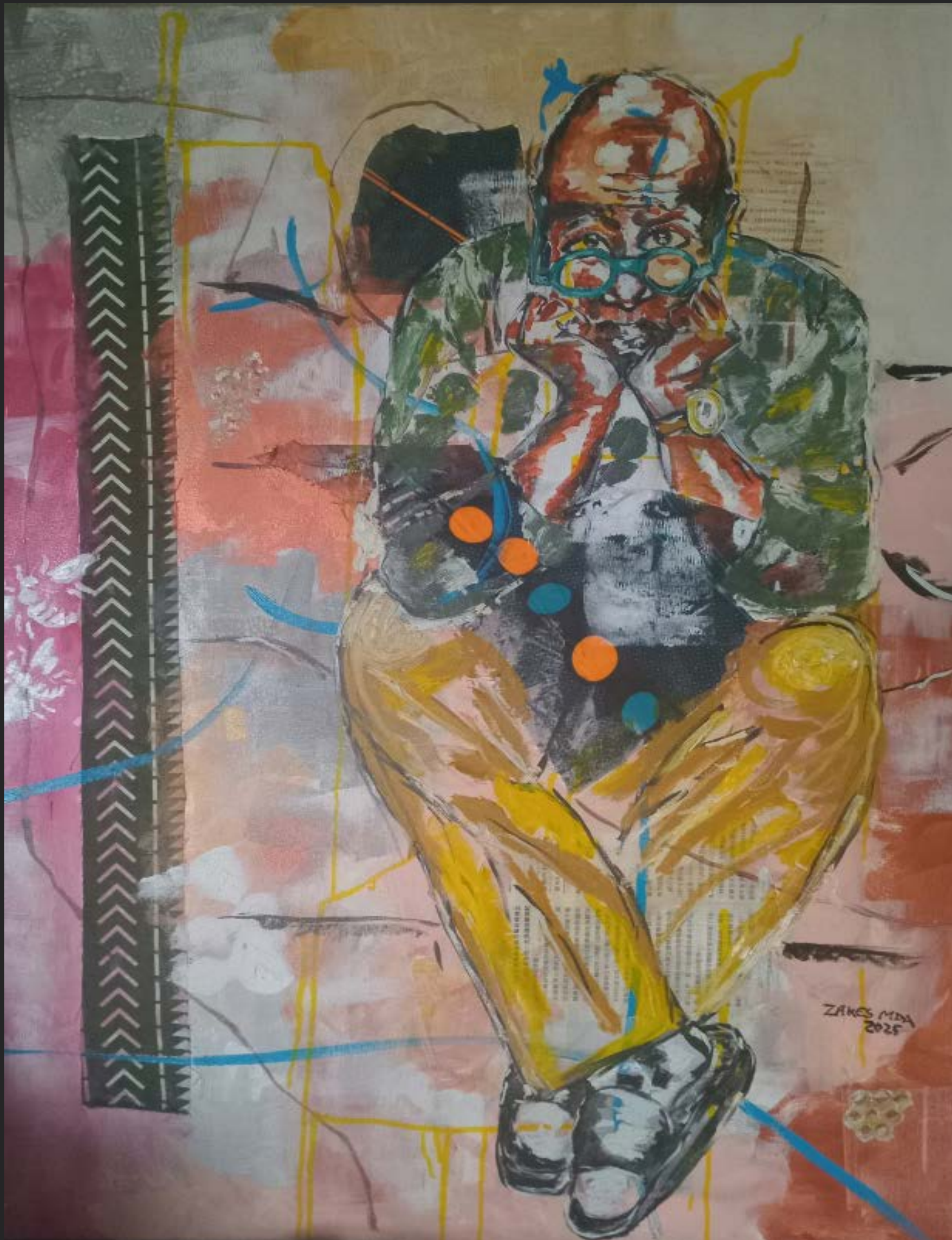
Hornman in meditation

2026

Mixed media on canvas
74 x 99cm

R60,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



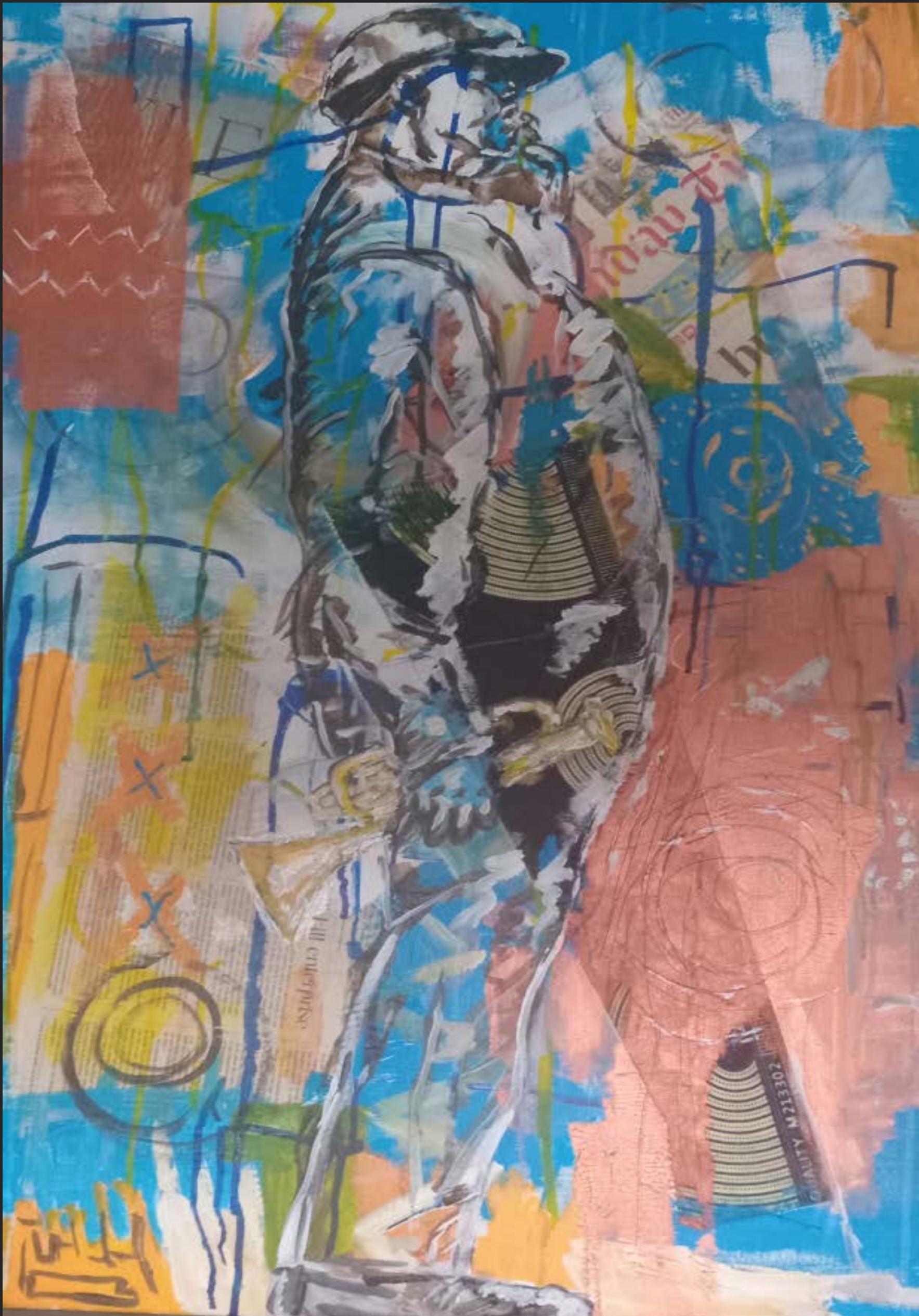
Artist in meditation II

2025

Mixed media on canvas
73 x 99cm

R60,000.00

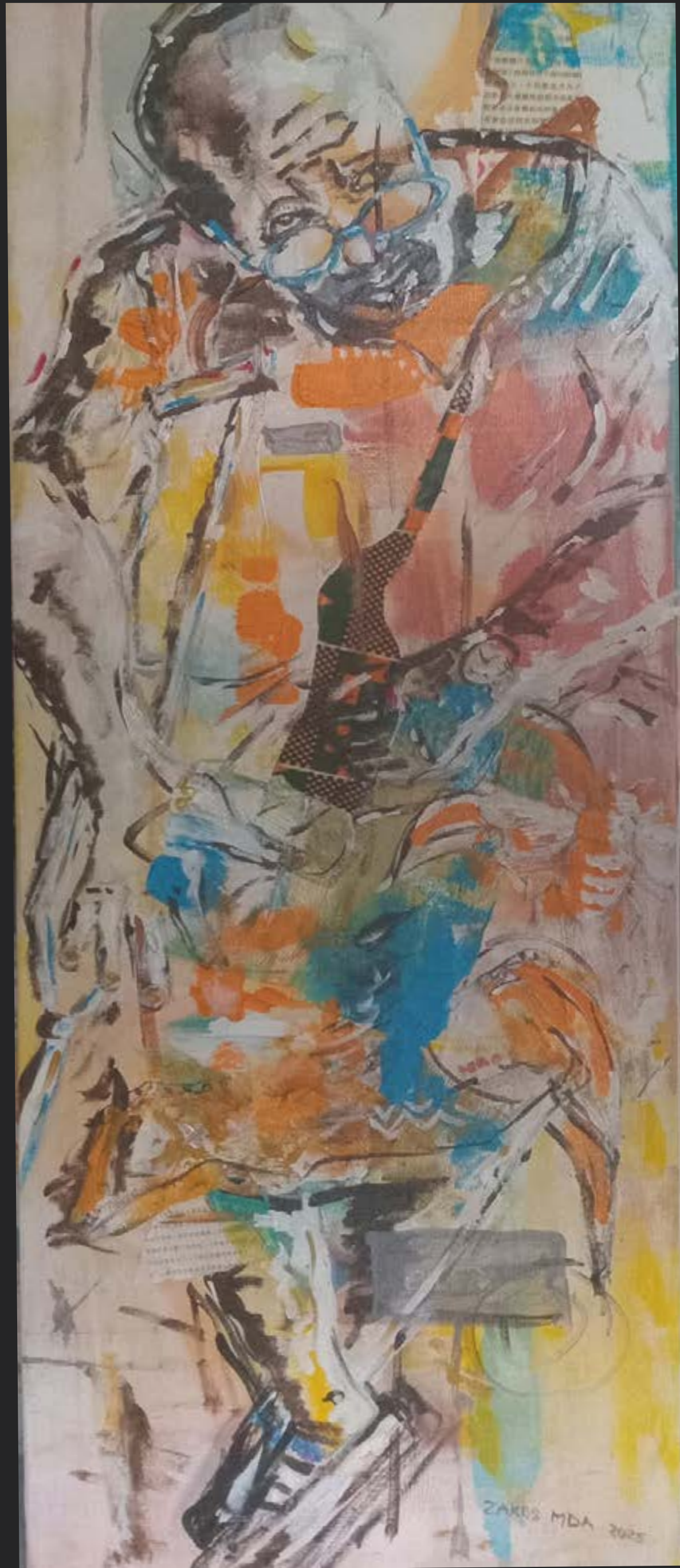
blessed by the **bees**



The Hornman
2025
Mixed media on canvas
58 x 91cm

R45,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



Untitled

2025

Mixed media on canvas
40 x 119cm

R80,000.00

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Blessed by the Bees

2025

Mixed media on canvas

73 x 58cm

R60,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



Jazz in Sepia I 2019

Mixed media on canvas
45 x 45cm

R35,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



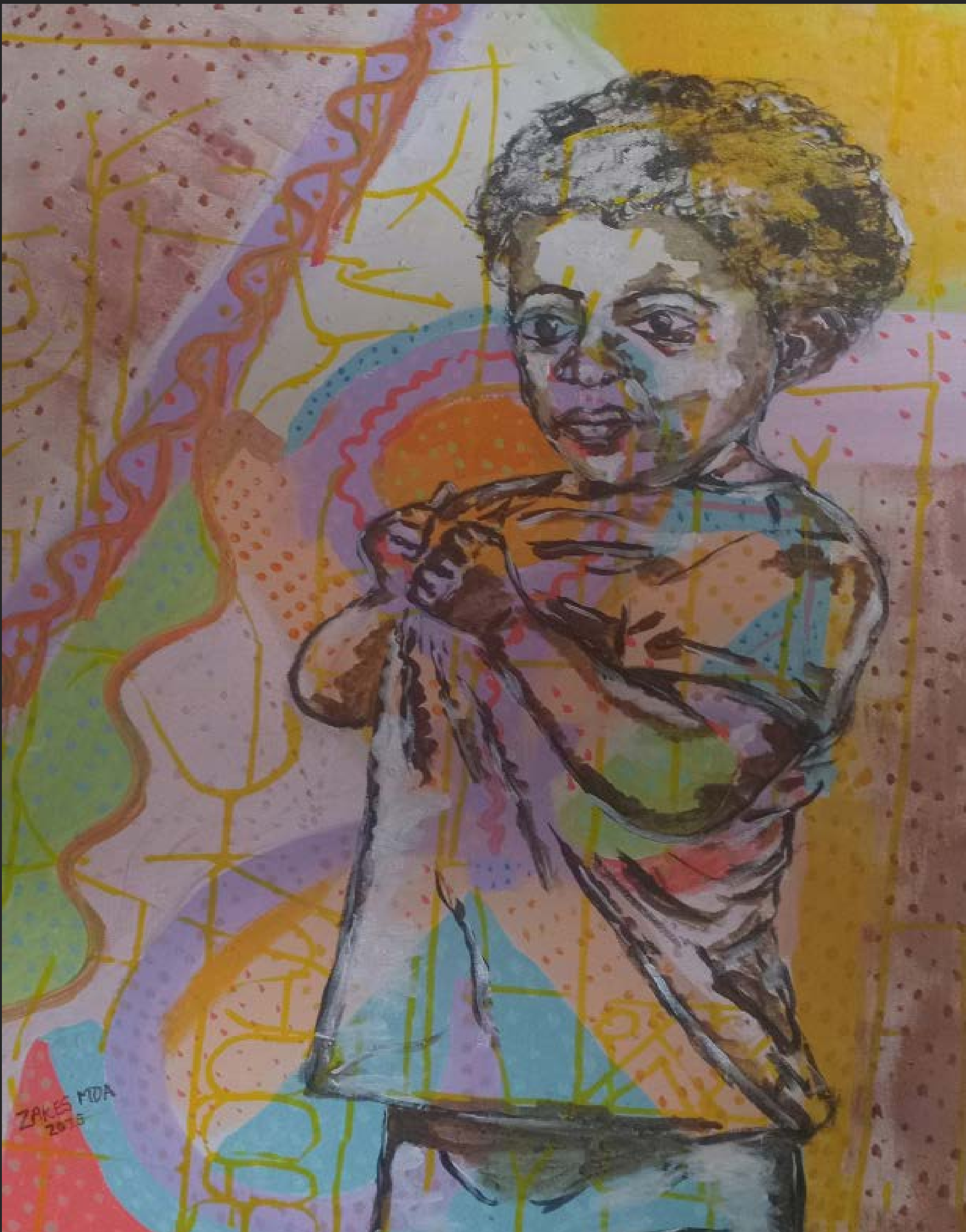
So sorry

2021

Mixed media on canvas
58 x 60cm

R45,000.00

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Granddaughter

2025

Mixed media on canvas
73 x 58cm

Not For Sale

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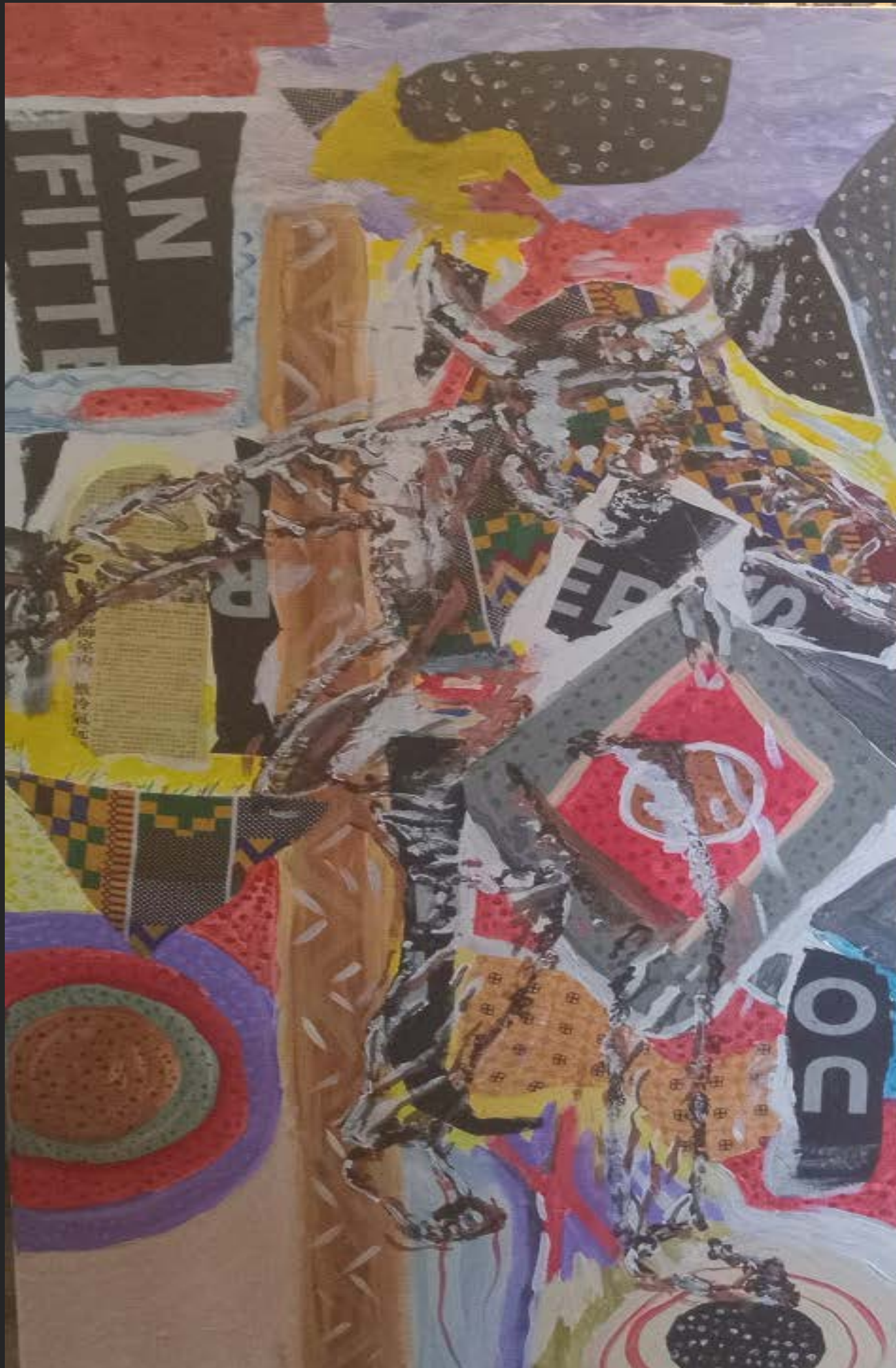
Racing to the Sun

2021

Mixed media on canvas
55 x 68cm

R45,000.00

blessed by the **bees**



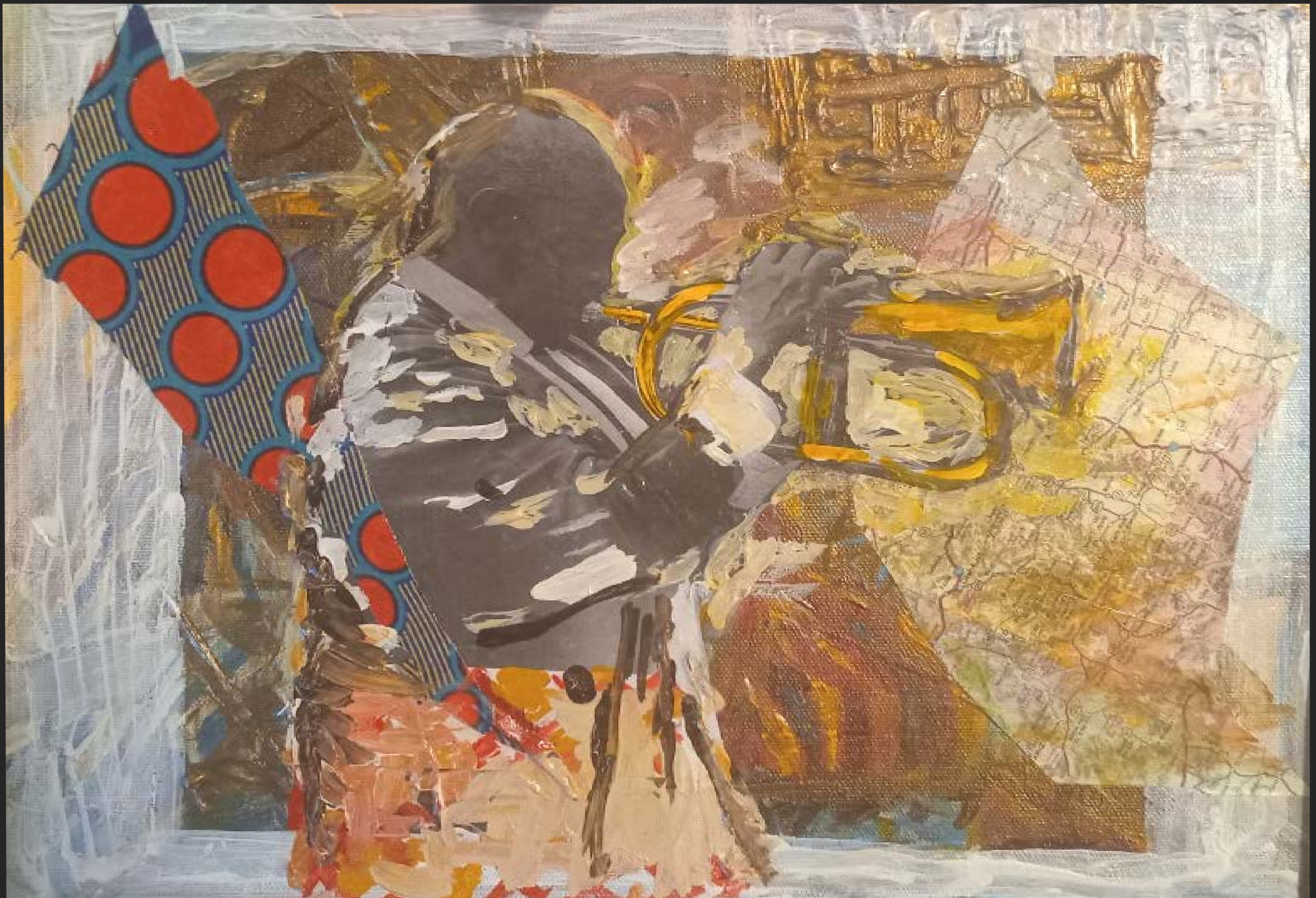
Maqoma (Diptych)

2023

Mixed media on canvas
117 x 119cm

R110,000.00

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Hughie

2017

Mixed media on canvas
35 x 30cm

Not For Sale

ABOUT SPRINGS ART GALLERY

The Springs Art Gallery is the only civic gallery in the City of Ekurhuleni.

To support departmental programs and the local visual arts industry, we have an on-going commitment to develop more creative partnerships between the art business communities in Ekurhuleni, thus enhancing the business skills within the arts sector and the creative engagement of the business sector.

This highly anticipated showcase marks the inaugural event for the venue following a comprehensive two-months period of critical repair, structural maintenance, and spatial modernization.

The project forms part of several partnerships/collaboration programmes implemented between the City of Ekurhuleni's Visual Arts and Galleries Section, artists, art groups, organisations, and institutions from the City of Ekurhuleni and beyond.

SPRINGS ART GALLERY

Library Building | C/o 5th Avenue & 6th Street | Springs CBD
Mon – Fri 9:00 – 16:00 Closed Weekends and Public Holidays

T: (011) 999 8726
e: sag@ekurhuleni.gov.za
w: www.ekurhuleni.gov.za
